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Boldfaced and Asterisks (*) indicate that the page should be **copied** and given to the DDGHP by February 1, 2016

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2015-2016 HIGH PRIEST PLANNING GUIDE*

Before you get started as High Priest you should first understand the powers of the office, and the duties you are required to perform. These are outlined in Art. C-095 and C-096 in The Constitution and Laws of the Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas.

Art. C-095 (235) Powers of the High Priest the High Priest shall have power:

- 1) To preside over all Convocations of his Chapter.
- 2) To appoint all officers of the Chapter whose election is not provided for in the laws.
- 3) To appoint all committees
- 4) To fill any vacancy in office, pro-tempore, for the period of the Convocation
- 5) To cause to be issued all summonses and notices which may be required.
- 6) To require all members of his Chapter present to vote upon all questions coming before the Chapter.
- 7) To discharge all executive functions of his Chapter
- 8) To represent his Chapter, together with the King and Scribe in this Grand Chapter
- 9) To exercise such other powers as may be granted him by the Constitution, Laws and Edicts of this Grand Chapter, or which by ancient custom and usage pertain to his office.

Art. C-096 (236) Duties of the High Priest shall be the duty of the High Priest:

- 1) To convene his Chapter in Stated Convocation at the time and place prescribed in the By Laws.
- 2) To have in his custody an up-to-date copy of the Constitution and Laws of this Grand Chapter, as shall be furnished by his Chapter. To suffer no violation of the Constitution, Laws and Edicts of this Grand Chapter or the By-Laws of his own Chapter upon any plea of convenience or expediency nor shall deviate there from without a dispensation from the Grand High Priest.
- 3) To see that all the officers of his Chapter faithfully perform the duties of their respective offices.
- 4) To prudently use the power of issuing summonses, but to see that disobedience of a summons is followed by prompt discipline unless a satisfactory excuse is rendered to the Chapter, and the Companion be excused therefore.
- 5) To see that the regular returns are made annually to this Grand Chapter within the time prescribed by law, and that the Grand Chapter fees are promptly paid.
- 6) To cause all necessary notices to be issued in the prescribed manner and form.
- 7) To permit to appeal from his decision to the Chapter; but an appeal may be allowed to the Grand High Priest during the recess of this Grand Chapter, subject to final action by this Grand Chapter, or the appeal may be made directly to this Grand Chapter. No appeal from a decision of the Grand High Priest will be reviewed by this Grand Chapter unless such decision was followed by some action, or non-action of the Chapter based thereon.
- 8) To see that the ritualistic and esoteric work practiced in his Chapter conforms to the work as approved by this Grand Chapter, to allow no innovations therein, and to prohibit the use of a Code Book or Plain Language Ritual for any purpose-including prompting or filling any station during Stated or Called Convocations or Degree Conferrals, except as specifically provided by Article B-100 (93-A) (Amended- 2003).
- 9) To perform such other duties as may be required by the Constitution, Laws and Edicts of this Grand Chapter.
- 10) That he immediately inform, or cause to be informed, each candidate exalted to

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High Priest Name _____

Phone _____

the sublime degree of a Royal Arch Mason that the Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas owns and maintains the Texas Masonic Retirement Center at Arlington, Texas (Amended-1993)

- 11) That he shall require the Chapter to devote at least one Convocation each year to an educational program concerning the Texas Masonic Retirement Center. (Amended- 1993)
- 12) To cause the name of each Companion of the Chapter who is in arrears for his dues to be assigned to a committee of three members of the Chapter. The High Priest may appoint as many such committees as might seem prudent by him. Each committee shall be provided with appropriate information regarding the Companion in arrears, and will collectively and individually make every reasonable effort to contact the Companion in arrears and encourage him to pay his dues. The Committee will report its findings to the Chapter and make such recommendations as might be appropriate to the charitable relief of any Companion who is unable to pay his dues. (Amended 2007)

Planning Your Officers and Committees

Why Plan?

In order to meet the standards of successful operations for a Royal Arch Chapter, a High Priest should engage in planning. Planning for year as High Priest is an essential step in order to ensure that: (1) you meet the standards for successful operations, and (2) you will have a successful term in office and that your chapter grows and prospers. This workbook should help you plan your year in office effectively. The more input that you receive from the Companions as you complete this form, the more useful this process will be for you. Remember – without involvement, there is no commitment! Involving your Companions to help you plan as a team gives you a much better chance of succeeding. Begin planning the year no later than December of the year prior to installation.

Requirement: Submit a copy of the pages with an asterisk (*) to your DDGHP no later than April 1 prior to your installation. Keep the entire workbook for your reference. Your DDGHP is happy to help you work on this form and can give you some good ideas in the process. Your DDGHP will copy the Most Excellent Grand High Priest.

Standards of Successful Operation For Chapters And Councils

By Robert P. Walker
V:E: Past Grand High Priest - 2001
The Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas

The following material has been prepared under the direction of The Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas, the Grand Council of Royal and Select Masters, and/or the Grand Commandery of Knights Templar of Texas.

Primary Standards

These standards are determined to be necessary for enhancing the dignity and efficiency of your meetings.

Each Officer should fill his station at all stated meetings, unless excused for reasonable cause.

Each Officer should be proficient in his station in the opening and closing ritual and floor work.

Each Officer should know and understand his duties at a stated meeting. (Example: Duties of an officer during a balloting procedure.)

The Presiding Officer prepares a "Business Agenda" for the meeting in accordance with the general order of business as set forth in Article 207 of the Laws of the R.A.M. of Texas and Article 174 of the Laws of the Grand Council of R.&S.M. of Texas and follows the pre-planned Agenda, thus promoting an orderly and timely meeting.

Examples of items that may be included are:

- Conferrals
- Presentations
- Special Programs
- Report future activities
- Activities and other Bodies
- Reports from the various Committees

Secondary Standards

These standards, if achieved, will not only continue to enhance professionalism in the meetings, but will aid in promoting growth and interest in the activities of the body.

Each Officer should strive to be proficient, in his station, in at least one of the Degrees of the Body.

The Presiding Officer should utilize the officers of the body whenever feasible to chair committees or otherwise provide input for the successful operation of the body.

The Bodies should strive to promote training in leadership and management for officers and other interested members. Sources include the Masonic Renewal Committee, the Warden's Retreat Program, and the Texas Lodge of Research.

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The Presiding Officer should plan to include, in each stated meeting, a short presentation (5 minutes or so) to the membership by some knowledgeable person on any topic of interest, not necessarily limited to a Masonic subject.

The Officers should develop and implement various ideas for including family members in at least some of the yearly activities of the Body.

Each Body should develop and implement methods of promoting the idea of York Rite membership in Blue Lodges. Some methods might include promotional programs, volunteer work, presentations, recognition programs, liaison officer, etc.

The Fraternal Bodies should work together to develop and implement ideas for community involvement.

Officers*

Select your chapter officers, based upon their availability, their competence, and their commitment to the craft. Assign each chapter officer some responsibility - give each officer something to contribute or oversee. Use the table below to draft your list.

Officer /Name	Responsibility
High Priest /	
Excellent King /	
Excellent Scribe /	
Treasurer /	
Secretary /	
Chaplain /	
Captain of the Host /	
Principal Sojourner /	
Royal Arch Captain /	
Master of the 3 rd Veil /	
Master of the 2 nd Veil /	
Master of the 1 st Veil /	
Guard /	

Note: This Planning Guide was first developed for M: E: Clarence J. Laney when he was Grand High Priest in 2007-2008, by the then State Coordinator, Dr. Karl J. Krayner, PHP.

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Committees*

Form chapter committees. Involving your Companions in meaningful committee work is an important way that they partner with each other and enjoy fellowship. Committees are also ways that keep the Companions busy doing the work of the chapter..

You are required to form some committees according to Grand Chapter Law. At your option, you may form other committees. Use the table below to draft a list of companions to invite to serve. Use an asterisk (*) to designate the Companion you wish to ask to chair the committee.

Committee Names	Companions
Required Standing Committees	
Finance (including Audit) - see Article C - 105 and Code of By-Laws, Article VI, Section 2(b)	
Charity (including Fraternal Assistance) – see Article C – 105 and Code of By-Laws, Article VI, Section 1(a)	
Sickness – see Code of By-Laws, Article VI, Section 2(a)	
Special Committees Required by Code of By-Laws see Article VI, Section 2(c)	
Membership (including Recruitment, Retention, and Reinstatement)	
Programs (including being “Ready and Willing to impart instruction, and receive the same”)	
Activities (including “Cultivating the Social Virtues”)	
Ritual Conferral either in the Chapter pursuant to Articles C-171, C-176, and C-177, or in a Festival pursuant to Articles C-178 in your Chapter or at another Chapter	

Planning your Year

Goals*

Goals give your chapter an accomplishment to aim for. They provide a common purpose and heighten enthusiasm toward achieving meaningful outcomes. All successful terms in office in any Masonic organization begin with clear, high performance goals. Your goal could be in membership, finance, social activity, Masonic Education, ritual proficiency, or any other area that you wish. Be creative!

Select one outcome that you would like to achieve by the end of your term, and mobilize activities and resources toward it.

“At the end of my term, I would like to have accomplished _____

 _____.”

Then, complete the following table with your Companions:

What You Have to Do To Accomplish the Goal	By When You Have to Do It	Who is Working on It
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		
6.		
7.		
8.		

Activity*

Select one social activity that you would like your chapter to host during your term. Pick an activity that will emphasize unique fellowship and capitalize upon family relationships that would be of interest to members.

This should be fun! The activity could be a dinner, board game night, visitation, sporting event, social night – the sky is the limit to what you could do. The Master of every Symbolic Blue Lodge is charged to cultivate the social virtues. Activities should be social!

The activity is: _____

We will hold this on _____.

In order to be successful, complete the following planning chart with your Companions:

What You Have to Do To Hold the Activity	By When You Have to Do It	Who is Working on It
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		
6.		
7.		
8.		
9.		
10.		
11.		
12.		

Sample Calendar

July

Open installation of officers **Section #7 on Zerubbabel Award**

August

At your dinner, have a widow's night **Section #10 on Zerubbabel Award**

September

Texas Masonic Retirement Center Program **Section #9 on Zerubbabel Award**

October

Have a Halloween dinner, and have a fundraiser for the TMRC **Section #9 on Zerubbabel Award**

November

Have a Thanksgiving dinner, and have each Sir Knight bring toys or clothing for the needy

December

Have a dinner to honor the Dill of Rights Day

January

For the meeting you can have a memorial service for the deceased members for the last year should be no more than 15 minutes of your regular meeting. For Ideas you could follow the format that the Grand Chapter uses at the Grand Session **Section #10 on Zerubbabel Award**

February

Invite your families, and have all the companions pass out flowers and valentine candy to all the ladies

March

St Joseph is honored in March and he raised a child that was not his own, so you can honor a youth leader. Have a fundraiser to help raise money for the local Masonic Youth organization, invite each of the Youth organization to join you at your meeting and have each give a short speech on their activities **Section #10 on Zerubbabel Award**

April

Have a Past High Priest night, have a dinner to honor all Past High Priest and have the senior Past High Priest speak last **Section #10 on Zerubbabel Award**

May

Have a meeting to honor those who have died in the service of our country

June

Have a dinner honoring the fathers in the Chapter

Here are several other items to remember when planning your year:

1. School of Instruction you should try to host one
 - a. Have all your officers attend
2. District Deputies Visits
 - a. November – February
 - b. July – September
3. Festivals
 - a. Should try to have at least two early spring and summer (January or February, and June and July)

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4. Visit other Chapters
 - a. At least three installed officers, one must be a dais officers
5. Attend Business Session of Grand Chapter (October)

Planning your Meetings

Masonic Education Programs*

Have one Masonic Educational Program at each stated meeting that focuses upon York Rite Masonry. Use this chart to align your topics for each meeting. Decide who will be responsible for presenting the program, or finding someone to present. NOTE: If your chapter does not meet every month, then complete this for the months that you do meet.

Month	Program Topic	Presenter or Responsible Companion
July		
August		
September		
October		
November		
December		
January		
February		
March		
April		
May		
June		

Sample Meeting Agenda

High Priest and Officers	Opening	
	Introduce visitors	
	Welcome all members and visitors	
High Priest	Call for reading of all unapproved minutes of previous Conclaves	5
Secretary	Reading of all unapproved minutes of previous Conclaves	10
High Priest	Call for the reports of All Committees	1
Chairmen of Committees	Reports of Committees	5
High Priest	Call for Receiving and Referring of Petitions	1
Secretary	Reads Petitions	5
High Priest	Calls for Report of Special Committees on Petitions	
Secretary	Reads Report on Petition	
High Priest	Calls for Balloting on Petitions	
Chapter Members	Vote on New Members	
High Priest	Call for Unfinished Business	1
Secretary	Unfinished Business	10
High Priest	Call for New Business	1
Chapter Members	New Business	10
High Priest	Calls for Correspondence from Grand Commandery	
Secretary	Reading of Correspondence from Grand Commandery	
High Priest	Calls for All Remaining Correspondence	
Secretary	Reading of All Remaining Correspondence	
High Priest	Presentation of Special Program	
High Priest	Calls for Treasurer's Report	
Treasurer	Reads Treasurer's Report	
	Calls for Sickness and Distress	
	General Comments	
	Recognize any Sir Knight deserving praise	
High Priest	Calls for Announcements	10
High Priest and Officers	Closing	

Remember election of officers falls in June, make sure you add it to your agenda in that month.

External Masonic Education For Symbolic Blue Lodges*

Sponsor one Masonic Educational Program to present at one of the Constituent Symbolic Blue Lodges within your chapter's territory. This could be about York Rite Masonry in general, or specifically on Capitular Masonry (Royal Arch Chapter). This program is one way for York Rite Masonry to be visible in our Symbolic Blue Lodges.

The Masonic Lodge or Lodges we will target is/are _____

Their stated meeting night is _____

Their WM in July, 2016 will be _____

His phone number is _____

Our preferred dates to present are _____

Topics that we could offer for a program are: _____

Companions who are responsible for coordinating this are:

Other notes about this program:

Note: See the Appendices in this booklet for programs that other Grand Jurisdictions have used.

Ritual*

Select one degree to work on during your term as High Priest.

Your goal should be to master the floor work and ritual and be able to confer the degree effectively by the end of your term. You may wish to invite a Committee on Work member to assist in tactics and evaluate your practice or conferral.

The degree my chapter will focus on is _____

Parts Required	Companions Who Know	Companions Who Will Learn

My goal is to be able to confer this degree on or before _____.

A target date to invite a member of the Committee on Work to a practice is _____

Practice dates are:

During your term, insist that the chapter officers open and close without the use of codebooks and rituals. Make time to practice the opening and closing.

Which meetings would you like to use for practicing the opening and closing?

Conferring of Degrees

The appropriate statutes regarding the conferral of degrees are as follows:

Art. C-171 (321) Degrees: Conferred Jointly: The degrees of Mark Master and Past Master may be conferred on more than one candidate at the same time, but only in the manner as adopted by the Grand Chapter and as taught and exemplified by the Committee on Work.

Art. C-176 (327) Most Excellent Degree: The Most Excellent Master Degree may be conferred upon any number of Brethren at one and the same time.

Art. C-177 (328) Royal Arch Degree: The Royal Arch Degree shall be conferred on not more or less than three persons at one and the same time, except the lecture and the charge, which may be given to any number; provided, substitute candidates, a representative candidate or a representative trio may be used under circumstances as provided by these laws.

Art. C-178 (328-A) York Rite Festival: One or more Subordinate Chapters in any Capitular District may confer the Degrees of Mark Master, Past Master, Most Excellent Master and a representative trio in the Royal Arch Degree. The sponsoring Chapter shall vote to conduct a York Rite Festival at a Stated Convocation. No degree or degrees shall be conferred upon a Candidate at a York Rite Festival unless he shall first present his Notice of Election (Form 8-B) attesting to his election to receive the degree or degrees and his payment of the fees for the degree or degrees to the Secretary of the Chapter which elected him. (Amended 2009)

The Grand High Priest shall be informed fifteen (15) days prior to conducting a Festival. (Amended – 1986)

Art. C-178.1 (328-B) Royal Arch Lecture: A Chapter may, as its option, insert the “Keys to the Mysterious Characters” presentation, following its mention in the lecture, with accompanying text and slides, as authorized by the Committee on Work of the Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas. (2008)

Chapter and Number _____ 15
High Priest Name _____ Phone _____

Questions?*

Is your chapter interested in hosting a York Rite Festival? ____yes ____ no

What date would your chapter be interested in for a York Rite Festival? _____

Have you read the handbook entitled “**How to Have a Successful Festival**”?

____yes ____ no

Note: This is available from your District Deputy Grand High Priest.

If your chapter is unwilling or cannot host a York Rite Festival, would your chapter be willing to take candidates to the nearest York Rite Festival? ____yes ____ no

Have you contacted the Grand Secretary, or the Grand High Priest, or viewed the York Rite website (www.texasorkrite.org) for Grand Chapter to see when and where a York Rite Festival would be available to your chapter candidates? ____yes ____ no

What is that place and what is that date? _____

Institute a plan to identify qualified candidates for York Rite Masonry, along with plans for contact and communication.

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The **New Candidate Orientation** is a meeting tool for retention. The text follows:

Candidates should receive a special invitation to attend the first stated convocation after their exaltation in order to participate in this orientation. This is true whether they are exalted at a festival or at an individual degree night in a chapter. The orientation is to be delivered by the High Priest, or another qualified companion, in open chapter with the assistance of available companions, where necessary. The lines in italics are suggested remarks that the High Priest or other qualified companion may paraphrase.

Congratulations and uniqueness

Explain that only 10% of Texas Masons become Royal Arch Masons

“Welcome! You are now a member of a unique group in Texas. Only one out of ten Master Masons in Texas has made the choice to receive additional light in Masonry by joining the York Rite. Congratulations upon your exaltation and welcome to _____ Chapter No. _____.”

Remind companions what they now know as a result of proceeding through these degrees – that they are better and more knowledgeable Masons:

“I mentioned additional light in Masonry that you received as you took the Chapter degrees in the York Rite. Here are some examples of what you have learned:

- *You now know the True word of a Master Mason, which you learned in the Royal Arch Degree.*
- *You now know how Fellowcraft Masons receive their wages, taught in the Mark Master Degree.*
- *You witnessed the final completion and dedication of the Temple in the Most Excellent Master Degree, which was in an unfinished state when you took your Master Mason’s degree.*
- *You now know how to properly rule and govern a lodge, armed with the lessons you learned in the Past Master Degree.”*

Unique customs

“Let’s talk about some of the traditions and customs that we practice in a chapter of Royal Arch Masons, many of which differ radically from what you are used to in your blue lodge:

- *When you are called upon, or wish to speak in the chapter, you stand, address and salute the High Priest, saying “Most Excellent.”*
- *We use a double gavel in rapid succession (demonstrate) and also talk while gaveling.*
- *We call each other ‘Companions,’ to illustrate that closer connection that we have among us as brother Masons.*

- *We use red as the unique color of the Royal Arch Degree. All the aprons and jewels, the logo, and paraphernalia of the chapter are red.*
- *In all cases, 'three' has a great significance in Royal Arch Masonry. We have three elected officers in the east representing our Ancient Grand Masters in the Grand Council, we require three candidates at exaltation, we have a 'triple tau' as a symbol (show), we gavel during the opening and closing three times of two gavels each, we use trios of companions to bring up the word at the opening and to deposit it at the closing, and many other examples of how we use three."*
- *Legally, it takes either nine or five companions to open and close a chapter, but nine companions is traditional and preferable. Keep the tradition!*
- *Our ritual is written out in plain English in codebooks. You may study with these, but they are not to be used while the chapter is open. We also have a monitor for the chapter degrees that specifies movement, floorwork, and tactics."*

Ritual

"I want to spend a few minutes ensuring that you are comfortable with the ritualistic traditions that we use here.

First, we will demonstrate bringing up the word in opening and depositing the word in closing. I would like to call upon these companions (name them) to demonstrate this, and then, I would like for you to participate as we do this again, to ensure you have it. Before we do so, remember that this is the word of a Royal Arch Mason (state the word slowly with clear three syllables), which is the long-lost Master's word.

Next, let's review the signs from Mark Master to Royal Arch Mason, inclusive. I would like for all companions to participate together for our new companion.

Are there any of these signs that you would like us to repeat for you?"

Grand Royal Arch Chapter

"You are well aware that the blue lodge is overseen by the Grand Lodge of Texas, with the Most Worshipful Grand Master of Masons in Texas. The Grand Lodge meets in Waco on the first weekend in December. In the Royal Arch Chapter, we also have a parent or superordinate body, the Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas. It has its own grand officers, with the presiding officer entitled the Most Excellent Grand High Priest. Other elected grand officers are the Right Excellent Grand King, Right Excellent Grand Scribe, Right Excellent Grand Treasurer, and Right Excellent Grand Secretary. There is also a full line of appointed grand officers along with elected and appointed committees. The Grand Royal Arch Chapter meets each year in Waco at the Grand Lodge building on the third Monday and Tuesday in October. At that meeting, the Grand Chapter conducts its annual business and elects officers. As a new Royal Arch Mason, you are now entitled to attend this session, and I hope that you will make plans to do so on the next occasion that it meets, which is _____."

Texas Masonic Retirement Center

“The Grand Royal Arch Chapter, which I just spoke of, has proudly sponsored the Texas Masonic Retirement Center (TMRC), for 100 years. The Center is located in Arlington, and typically houses 70 senior citizens who are either Masons, or relatives of Masons. The Center offers beautiful, relaxing accommodations amid 100 acres of sweeping grassland, wildflowers, and a century-old pecan orchard. The residents enjoy quiet country living and fill their days with countless activities, knowing that their privacy is respected and their independence is honored. The Main Building has a variety of apartments. Also, there are two bedroom duplex units and a luxury apartment building with upscale interiors. Wireless internet is available to all residents. A skilled nursing clinic is on the grounds of the facility. The TMRC offers a fine environment for its residents, with many opportunities for recreation, good food, and rest, along with excellent physical care and hygiene. There are two payment options for eligible Royal Arch Masons and certain family members: payment for services, or total asset turnover which includes lifetime care.”

“I encourage you to visit the Texas Masonic Retirement Center at your earliest convenience. Once a year in our chapter, we have a program on the Center, and this is scheduled for _____.”

“I would like to open the floor to you for questions about anything I have mentioned in this orientation.”

“I would now like to give you the opportunity to speak to our chapter, and say whatever is on your mind and heart.”

The following information is a tool for membership recruitment:

YORK RITE LIGHT

Karl J. Krayner, PHP, PTIM

George Washington Chapter No. 422 - John C. Callahan Council No. 408

We often tell prospective candidates that one of the benefits of joining the York Rite is that they will receive additional light, as our degrees complete many of the stories and extend many of the lessons that they received in their blue lodge degrees. What, specifically, can we tell the candidates that they will learn? Here is a quick list of **York Rite Light**, with the corresponding degree, as the candidates will learn:

- How to receive wages as a Fellowcraft Mason (Mark Master^o)
- How the builder made the principal keystone for the temple and how it was recovered
 - o (Mark Master^o)
- How to govern a Masonic body as a presiding officer (Past Master^o)
- What happened at the final dedication and completion of the temple (Most Excellent Master^o)
- Recovery of the “lost word or true word” of a Master Mason (Royal Arch^o)
- The destruction and plans for rebuilding the temple (Royal Arch^o)
- The builder’s prophecy about the lost word of a Master Mason (Royal Master^o)
- How the “lost word or true word” of a Master Mason was deposited for the benefit of future generations (Select Master^o) until it was recovered in the Royal Arch Degree
- How work in the temple was preserved for antiquity and later discovered by future generations (Select Master^o)
- How the rebuilt temple was destroyed in a siege at Jerusalem (Super Excellent Master^o)
- How the Jewish Nation was released from their captivity in Babylon and returned to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple (Order of the Red Cross)
- How the true word of a Master Mason became flesh and walked among us (Order of the Temple)

This is quite a list! It is clear that any Master Mason who does not take the York Rite degrees is truly missing valuable information about Freemasonry. There is great value for any Master Mason to finish his Masonic experience and education by completing the York Rite Masonic journey begun in the Symbolic Blue Lodge. Remember it is not the destination, but the journey for more and further light that is important.

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Elevator Speech*

Provide Master Masons who are not York Rite Masons with an “elevator speech” that clearly and concisely describes York Rite Masonry – what it is, what it does, what its benefits are to new members.

Customize this for your chapter and your Companions by holding a discussion at one of your meetings. Take a stab at this yourself before reading the sample on page 19

What is York Rite Masonry?

What do we do in our Chapter that will be attractive to a non-member?

What are the benefits of joining?

Every York Rite Mason should be able to give clear and concise responses to these three questions in the time that it takes an elevator to move 3-5 floors. Your ability to give these responses has direct impact upon whether prospective members decide to petition.

What is York Rite Masonry?

The York Rite of Freemasonry is open to any Master Mason in good standing. The York Rite is comprised of three bodies, each with its own line of officers and ritual, and charitable activity. These are the chapter of Royal Arch Masons, council of Royal and Select Masters, and Commandery of Knights Templar. Unlike the blue lodge, candidates in the York Rite do not need to complete any proficiency examination of memory work. And like in the blue lodge, but unlike in the Scottish Rite, the method of presentation we use in our degrees involves active participation from the candidates, which adds meaning and impact for everyone.

What do we do in our Chapter and Council that will be Attractive to a Non-Member?

First, we have fun. It is great to get together with Masons from different blue lodges to share ideas, hear about activities, and support each other. Second, we are dedicated to sharing more Masonic light with our candidates by participating in our degrees and giving them a quality experience, along with our "short talk" programs and discussions at our meetings. Third, many of our activities involve our families, and the York Rite provides an opportunity for everyone to meet and spend time with good people.

What are the Benefits of Joining the York Rite?

York Rite Masons are better Masons because of the two main benefits of joining. First, you will receive valuable instruction and lessons that complete many of the stories and lessons that you learned in your blue lodge degrees. These include the completion of King Solomon's temple, the recovery of the long lost Master Mason's Word, and many others that you will enjoy learning. Second, you may enjoy fellowship with Masons from several different lodges in your area, thus extending your Masonic connections, and experiencing the meaning of true universal brotherhood.

Chapter and Number _____ 23
High Priest Name _____ Phone _____

Questions For Grand Chapter Officers*

What questions could one of the Grand Chapter officers answer for you?

How could Grand Chapter officers be of particular assistance to you?

When is the best time to reach you? _____

What number should we use? _____

**A copy of the asterisked (*) pages of this workbook is due to your District Deputy
Grand High Priest by April 1, 2016. Retain the book for your reference.**

APPENDICES

Membership Development Booklet
By Daniel Hogue – Past Grand High Priest – North Carolina
<http://www.ramint.org/downloads/GGCMembershipBooklet.pdf>

Membership Development Booklet By
Grand Chapter of Ohio
<http://www.ramint.org/downloads/Ohio.pdf>

Membership Development By Louis E. Bartrand
<http://www.ramint.org/downloads/Bertrand.pdf>

Membership – North Carolina Program
<http://www.ramint.org/downloads/NorthCarolina.pdf>

Fervency and Zeal
Royal Arch Program from New York and Maryland
<http://www.ramint.org/downloads/FERVENCY&ZEAL.pdf>

California Gonzales Plan for Membership
<http://www.ramint.org/downloads/Gonzalez.pdf>

York Rite College Sovereign Self-Study Program
<http://www.yrscna.org/forms/YorkRiteenrollmentform.pdf>

Explanation of Zerubbabel Award Scoring by DDGHP's – 2015-2016

This is a general explanation of the **Zerubbabel Award** as graded by your **DDGHP** on two official visits. The District Deputy Grand High Priest will be able to answer any questions you may have at any time. The grading is required by the Laws of the Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas, as outlined in Article B-084.1.

This award/report has been created to give the chapter leaders an idea of the things that will help them improve their Chapter's proficiency, pride, and esprit de corps among the Officers and Companions. The Zerubbabel Award for the Chapters is similar to the Grand Lodge Vanguard Award and the Grand Commandery Cross and Crown Award.

Here is an overview of the requirements:

1. York Rite Conferences. The York Rite Conferences are a very important part of the Grand Chapter program, and many elected officers do not attend for various reasons. Many times there are programs that are presented to help the elected officer with the management of their chapters. This section covers conferences attendances and states that a chapter is not eligible to receive this award if one of the three principle officers (HP, EK, ES), does not attend the conference.
2. Regular Meetings - What you do at meetings to increase the value for the membership. The score will be totaled on his Official Visit.
3. District Deputy Official Visit - Self-explanatory. The score will be totaled on his Official Visit.
4. Opening/Closing Proficiency – Self-explanatory. If a book is used by anyone other than the prompter, no points. One learns by listening to the ritual and getting “into the flow” of it. The reception of the DDGHP or any Grand Officer should be practiced, especially when you know his date of visitation.
5. Degree Proficiency – If your Chapter can confer any Degree without use of the ritual book you will receive credit for being proficient in that Degree. It does not matter who is in what station as long as he is a member of your Chapter.
6. Secretary/Records – Self – explanatory.
7. Designed to encourage the Chapter to have all Officers present at installation. Every Chapter should know a month or two in advance when it will hold installation. Every elected and appointed Officer should be there excepting personal emergency. Elected Officers cannot be proxied (Article C-091) and must be installed prior to August 1st unless dispensation is granted. This is graded on the 2nd visitation only.
8. On the first visit, this applies to the Grand Royal Arch Chapter Annual Convocation.
9. The Texas Masonic Retirement Center is owned and operated by the Grand Royal Arch Chapter of Texas. To qualify for points, the date of the presentation and the name of the presenter must be entered into the minutes of that meeting, Stated or Called. Program material is available from TMRC. Call or write Companion Gary Blair (Superintendent) for presentation material at phone (817) 275-2893, fax (817) 275-1065 1501 W. Division St., Arlington 76012, or e-mail gary@txmrc.org.

The Chapter will receive points for having representation at Festivals as shown. It should be self-evident to all of us that when we have a candidate at another Chapter for degree work, we should be there to help shepherd him through the process.

Anything not listed, but of help in improving the Chapter or showing Community participation by us as Royal Arch Masons will be awarded 25 bonus pts per action.

Chapters that do not participate in Festivals because they fully confer their own degree work are entitled to a bonus of **300 points** to equate the points given to Chapters that participate in Festivals because they do not or cannot confer their own degrees.

All Chapters are scored starting at Zero (0) and points are added for all the activities that provide evidence that the Officers are working together to build working Chapters.

Chapter and Number _____ 26
High Priest Name _____ Phone _____

Zerubbabel Award Score Sheet
District Deputy Grand High Priest Report - 1st Visitation
Between November 1, 2015 and July 31, 2016

Chapter _____ No. _____ Date _____ District _____

1. York Rite Conferences

Elected Officers present:

HP _____ EK _____ ES _____ Tr _____ Sec _____ _____ / 50 pts

Installed Officers: 10 Points each; Total of 50 Points; HP, EK, or ES must be present to qualify for award

Appointed Officers present:

Chap _____ COH _____ PS _____ RAC _____ 3V _____ 2V _____ 1V _____ GD _____ _____ / 80 pts

Installed Officers: 10 Points each; Total of 80 Points

Members: 5 Points each _____ / 5 pts each

District Deputy Grand High Priest

Most Excellent High Priest

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Grand High Priest by April 1, 2016. Retain the book for your reference.

YORK RITE LIGHT

Karl J. Kraye, PHP, PTIM

George Washington Chapter No. 422 - John C. Callahan Council No. 408

We often tell prospective candidates that one of the benefits of joining the York Rite is that they will receive additional light, as our degrees complete many of the stories and extend many of the lessons that they received in their blue lodge degrees. What, specifically, can we tell the candidates that they will learn? Here is a quick list of **York Rite Light**, with the corresponding degree, as the candidates will learn:

- How to receive wages as a Fellowcraft Mason (Mark Master^o)
- How the builder made the principal keystone for the temple and how it was recovered (Mark Master^o)
- How to govern a Masonic body as a presiding officer (Past Master^o)
- What happened at the final dedication and completion of the temple (Most Excellent Master^o)
- Recovery of the “lost word or true word” of a Master Mason (Royal Arch^o)
- The destruction and plans for rebuilding the temple (Royal Arch^o)
- The builder’s prophecy about the lost word of a Master Mason (Royal Master^o)
- How the “lost word or true word” of a Master Mason was deposited for the benefit of future generations (Select Master^o) until it was recovered in the Royal Arch Degree
- How work in the temple was preserved for antiquity and later discovered by future generations (Select Master^o)
- How the rebuilt temple was destroyed in a siege at Jerusalem (Super Excellent Master^o)
- How the Jewish Nation was released from their captivity in Babylon and returned to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple (Order of the Red Cross)
- How the true word of a Master Mason became flesh and walked among us (Order of the Temple)

This is quite a list! It is clear that any Master Mason who does not take the York Rite degrees is truly missing valuable information about Masonry. There is great value for any Master Mason to complete his Masonic experience and education by taking our degrees.

Every York Rite Mason should be able to give clear and concise responses to these three questions in the time that it takes an elevator to move 3-5 floors. Your ability to give these responses has direct impact upon whether prospective members decide to petition.

What is York Rite Masonry?

The York Rite of Freemasonry is open to any Master Mason in good standing. The York Rite is comprised of three bodies, each with its own line of officers and ritual, and charitable activity. These are the chapter of Royal Arch Masons, council of Royal and Select Masters, and Commandery of Knights Templar. Unlike the blue lodge, candidates in the York Rite do not need to complete any proficiency examination of memory work. And like in the blue lodge, but unlike in the Scottish Rite, the method of presentation we use in our degrees involves active participation from the candidates, which adds meaning and impact for everyone.

What do we do in our Chapter and Council that will be Attractive to a Non-Member?

First, we have fun. It is great to get together with Masons from different blue lodges to share ideas, hear about activities, and support each other. Second, we are dedicated to sharing more Masonic light with our candidates by participating in our degrees and giving them a quality experience, along with our "short talk" programs and discussions at our meetings. Third, many of our activities involve our families, and the York Rite provides an opportunity for everyone to meet and spend time with good people.

What are the Benefits of Joining the York Rite?

York Rite Masons are better Masons because of the two main benefits of joining. First, you will receive valuable instruction and lessons that complete many of the stories and lessons that you learned in your blue lodge degrees. These include the completion of King Solomon's temple, the recovery of the long lost Master Mason's Word, and many others that you will enjoy learning. Second, you may enjoy fellowship with Masons from several different lodges in your area, thus extending your Masonic connections, and experiencing the meaning of true universal brotherhood.

The General Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons International



Membership Development Booklet

**Compiled and Edited by:
Daniel M. Hogue, Jr. Ph.D.,
Past Grand High Priest - North Carolina**

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General Grand Chapter Of Royal Arch Masons Membership Development Booklet

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Introduction

York Rite Masonry has a wonderful story to tell and a tremendous history to share. Unfortunately, somewhere along the line, we decided that the story would tell itself and that we need do no more than exist and they would join. “Kinda” like the baseball movie where it was said, *“Build it and they will come”*. Well, that style of thinking only works in Hollywood. In real life, membership takes a concerted effort and must be worked like your garden. Our goal is to provide the tools with which to work the garden where the crops will be new members who share the enthusiasm of York Rite Masonry that we do.

At the February 2004 Finance Meeting in Monroe, North Carolina, we discovered that if the York Rite Bodies continue to lose members at the rate we are now losing them, York Rite in North Carolina will be a thing of the past in 2018. That is 14 years. This is a sobering fact and calls us all to action.

No York Rite Body can rest on its past laurels and/or accomplishments. We are living in a different world today where TIME is the essential ingredient for the younger man. He has to know that trading his time from one item to another will bring him dividends. The organization for which he gives up time at home with his family must be a vibrant, well-oiled machine and must be something for which he will gladly say, “I belong”.

It is imperative that every York Rite Mason take a personal interest in our growth. The invitation to become a York Rite Mason should come from York Rite Masons themselves. We need to be active in our Blue Lodges and speak often of York Rite. We must lead by example. We should be the ones who initiate the invitation to our Blue Lodge Brothers. A campaign will be successful only because each of us is willing to be a positive and proactive contributor to each and every step of the program.

It is no longer valid to say, “But we have always done it that way”, or “We have never done it that way”. The whole scheme of live has changed and we have to adapt to the fast paced age in which we live. Let it be said

here that we must never sacrifice any of our principles, but we must change our methods if we intend to attract new recruits and grow.

There is a sense of urgency about all this. Remember the 14 years stated above. In these times of boundless choice, men must be continually “sold” on the discretionary items in life. It is, therefore, imperative that we modernize our thinking in recruiting members for the York Rite. Now is the time to promote a membership effort that reaches recruits, current members, and those members we may have opportunity to “re-up”.

“We have come up thus far to help, aid, and assist in the building of our city and the House of the Lord, without the hope of fee or reward.”

It is the intention of this program and your Membership committee to promote a carefully planned, energetic, and dignified campaign that will strengthen and build our ranks. The future of Royal Arch Masonry is in our hands.

The 3 R's of Membership

Recruitment – Recognition – Retention

The three R's of any campaign are recruitment, recognition, and retention. They are the foundation upon which any campaign must be built.

RECRUITMENT: The lifeline of any organization is built upon new members. Without a new base of membership, we cannot reach the heights that our wonderful York Rite so richly deserves. We intend to present a workable, viable recruitment program that is a time tested tool that works.

RECOGNITION: Many of our Companions accomplish awards worthy of being recognized at our monthly Convocations. Make a concerted effort to learn both the recipient and the award. Then insure that this individual attends your next Convocation and have a knowledgeable member make a presentation to him west of the Altar. Folks love hearing their names. Find a way to accommodate this phenomenon.

RETENTION: Often, the only thing a wavering brother needs is encouragement. We can turn the tide of NPD's with a friendly call or visit, informing the member of the importance of his remaining with the York Rite. A phone tree can do wonders in keeping members informed and teaching them that the York Rite has value for them.

Each York Rite body needs to appoint a Membership Chairman, and give him a committee consisting of a Chairman for Recruitment, a Chairman for Recognition, and a Chairman for Retention. This team needs to consist of men who are active and will WORK. List this team among your committees on your annual listings. Make it a priority.

Selecting the Membership Team

Essential to the success of any membership program is the selection of its chairman. He must be a man who possesses people skills and who is willing to assume the helm. He must have the time, possess organizational, planning, and sales abilities and have the respect of his peers. The position of Membership Chairman is, in the long run, the most critical decision your Chapter will make. His selection, as well as his acceptance, should be based upon the most vital question of, “Can he lead us to success in our membership drive?”

Second only to this selection will be the one of the membership team members who should hold the positions of Recruitment Chairman, Recognition Chairman, and Retention Chairman. These hand picked men will compose the team that will lead the efforts of the Bodies. Select men who will follow their leader, but who possess the skills and dedication to step out on their own in their area of expertise. These men must be of a mind bent to understand that membership is a never-ending process.

Before the work of the team begins, much planning must be done. The team must determine the names, numbers, and locations of the Blue Lodges served by their Chapter. They must know the meeting night of each Lodge, its Secretary and Master.

The team will then want to establish an “Ambassador” program for each Blue Lodge and then carefully pick the proper Ambassador for each Lodge. An annual meeting of the Ambassadors is a must. Dates of Festivals, picnics, awards presentations, etc., should be covered in this meeting, as well as providing each Ambassador with a roster of each York Rite member in his Lodge.

Realizing that membership is an on-going process, the team will want to be in contact with its Ambassadors (via e-mail) on a regular basis. All information brought to the attention of the Blue Lodge concerning the York Rite rests within the hands of the Ambassadors.

The primary ingredient in the recipe for a successful membership team is the establishment of an organizational structure with clearly defined areas of responsibility and an obvious reporting system.

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Organized Planning for Membership Training

A membership campaign requires careful planning before it is launched. Any York Rite Body that rushes into a membership program without a careful, deliberate, detailed, and well thought out plan is apt to fail.

The FIRST consideration you will want to do is evaluate your situation.

How many members do you now have?

Of that number, how many are active?

How many Blue Lodges do you serve?

How many members do they have?

How many of your members are willing to share in the workload?

Can you do all the Ritual – or do you need help?

Would a new member be excited about what you do?

You will want to evaluate your own situation prior to asking Blue Lodge members to join your Bodies. But most of all, you must be willing to hear everything your members have to say – positive or negative. Sometimes the truth hurts, but we can only begin from where we are, and not from where we think we are. (remember – statistics tell us we only have 14 years remaining before the good ship York Rite sinks)

You must make a plan and then follow the plan. It does not matter which way the wind blows when the ship has lost its sail. Your plan must be accepted by the loyal and dependable members of your York Rite Bodies, otherwise no one will work the plan. The plan must be placed into the hands of those who will give it the time and effort until conclusion, YOUR membership Team.

A word about goals. Goals must be high enough to be challenging, but low enough to achieve. Be sure to set your goals for new members at an acceptable rate. And do set a goal. Give it a number. IE: We will attain 17 new members in the year 2004. Set goals for new members. Church statistics inform us that it takes far more effort to get a fallen member back into the fold than it is to gain a new member. So, strive for the new members.

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Take the time to do the preparation work. Make sure all players are on the same page and singing the same tune. The few hours spent in preparation will save untold hours of effort. Athletes practice hours to play minutes. They prepare. Planning will spell the difference between success and failure.

We can bring the York Rite back to the prominence it has enjoyed in the past. With less than fifteen (15) percent of Blue Lodge Members belonging to the York Rite, we have untold opportunities in the Blue Lodges.

“The fields are great to harvest, but the laborers are few.”

Recruiting Master Masons to the York Rite

The Recruitment Chairman should notify, by mail, each Blue Lodge within the jurisdiction of that York Rite Body in October of each year, that the York Rite will be willing to attend a Blue Lodge meeting and present an educational program on the York Rite of Freemasonry – in costume. These last two words – in costume – are most important.

After a Blue Lodge has arranged for a program, three knowledgeable and active York Rite members should be selected to attend the Lodge and present the York Rite story in five (5) parts and in costume. This means that the Chapter man should wear a red coat, the Council man should wear a purple coat, and the Commandery man should wear his uniform without chapeau and sword. The program should be presented as follows:

1. **Introduction** - This part short and sweet to inform the Blue Lodge how the program will be presented and to assure them the program will take no longer than twenty (20) minutes.
2. **Chapter** - The first part should cover the Chapter. It must be presented by a Royal Arch Mason (red coat and chapter jewelry – including apron and jewel). He should cover Mark Master, Past Master, Most Excellent Master, Royal Arch Mason and R.A.R.A. This part of the program should not dwell simply on ritual, but should place emphasis on the understanding that without the Royal Arch, a Mason's education is incomplete.
3. **Council** - The second part should cover the Council. The companion should be dressed in purple and wearing his apron and jewel. He should cover Royal and Select Master and mention the Super Excellent Master. He should close with Cryptic Masons Medical Research.
4. **Commandery** - The third part should cover the Commandery. The presenter should wear a full uniform and a Blue Lodge apron. He should cover the Orders of the Commandery and finish with Knight Templar Eye Foundation.
5. **Conclusion** - A question and answer session should follow and should always conclude with a big thank you to the Master and the Lodge for allowing a York Rite program to be presented in their Lodge.

It is always appropriate to leave the Blue Lodge Secretary with a packet of information on the York Rite, with – of course – several petitions for his members. Always remember to be enthusiastic and personable.

Other forms of communications with non-members include:

- The personal (one on one) touch
- Lead by example
- Wear the appropriate “costume” whenever possible
- Participate in parades
- Hold open houses
- Mail personal letters to newly made Master Masons
- Have a specific honoree for your festivals
- Form a speaker’s bureau from your gifted speakers and make the list available to Blue Lodges, Scottish Rite Valleys, and the Shrine

It is very important that our members know as much as possible about the Chapter. Having Masonic education, sharing knowledge on an informal basis, reading, and attendance do much to make our members literate. Want other justification? How about

We improve York Rite Masons in every walk of life through their work and study of our craft.

We stand for the noblest principles in the lives of men and the highest standards of conduct.

We let our light so shine before men that they may see our good works and glorify their Supreme Being.

We share character building through a liberal education that may be shared with one another.

We provide a rich sense of fellowship, freedom of mind, and an understanding of that which is right to live harmoniously with God and man.

We learn through participation in our Degrees, thereby advancing our understanding – up to and including the finding of the lost word.

We share our wonderful history and heritage through participation with other Companions.

We meet and learn to know some mighty fine men who otherwise might have remained at a perpetual distance.

Membership Development is a Key

As you begin your campaign, there are a few thoughts you will want to consider. They include:

This is not the York Rite of the 1960's: It is true that the numbers may not as large as they once were, but because of the actions of the Shrine a few years ago, the new members we now get are as sold out to the mission as we are and they are willing and ready to go to work when then complete the Degrees and Orders of the York Rite. They come in all ages and sizes. They bring with them new ideas and an opportunity to help us grow. They bring a most welcomed energy transfusion.

Membership Value is critical: Our new members are busy people and they need to be convinced that the dollars they spend with us are returning a value to them in ways other than carrying another membership card. Our members are interested in family activities, guest speakers, community involvement, and an opportunity of being of service. They need to know that by committing their time and talents that they are making a positive contribution to a worthwhile organization. You will want to sell these men on the wonderful value to the Chapter.

Becoming an internet Fraternity: More and more of our members are becoming “connected”. Many of our Bodies are also on the internet. Rest assured that younger prospects check you out on the internet before they invest their hard earned money to become a part of this Body. Web sites promote our Bodies and our mission and are a big seller for younger men. This media improves communications, saves postage, and updates the York Rite in the eyes of the beholder. Being a “dot.com” fraternity can be a differentiating factor in gaining membership.

Dangling the carrot: Many York Rite Bodies have instituted incentives to reward members who have excelled, be it top- line signing or contributions in other areas of our fraternity and the community. Consider incentives for these men who walk the extra mile, be they dues credit, gift certificates, or recognition in Chapter meetings. This program works. Give it a try.

Festivals are reunions: A festival is both an opportunity to gain new members and renew acquaintances. Make sure that your entire membership knows of your Festivals and feel welcome to come and enjoy both the ritual and the fellowship. Be sure to establish an “organizing team” and charge them with the responsibility of insuring successful completion of your Festival. Publicize and promote.

Promote – Promote – Promote: No program can ever be successful without promotion. Take every opportunity to promote the York Rite and its activities. Write articles, take pictures, publish them on the internet under your web site. No one can buy something he doesn’t know about.

Perception is reality: Make no mistake about it, what others see in you is what they perceive to be the truth. Although you may know your Chapter inside and out, both ways ‘til Tuesday, but outsiders do not. Remember the old axiom that the chain is only as strong as its weakest link. Often insiders know very little also. With a minority of our members ever gracing the door of our meetings, what is the perception of those who do not? They are, after all, the vast majority. House cleaning begins at home. Are our inactive members our dissatisfied customers? We need to know what inspires the non-attenders. We need to contact these men and ask the hard questions. What are their recommendations? Yogi Berra once said that, “You hear a lot by listening”. Our product may need some tweaking to meet the needs of those inactive men. Perception issues can be managed. With the implementation of true management tools, we can see our Bodies through the eyes of others and can then take advantage of one of the greatest opportunities for customer satisfaction and growth.

Successful Recruiting = More Petitions

Success results from hard work. It does not come easily nor does one fall into success through sheer luck. Goal attainment comes from approaching every project from a variety of ways – as opposed to putting all one’s eggs into one basket. Diverse and creative thinking is necessary for the Membership team if your Chapter is to gain in membership. A prepared and well-worked attack plan is necessary on all fronts for you to have a better chance at success. Effectiveness is the key. Plan your assault on various fronts. Have you considered?

Mailing each member of your York Rite Bodies a personal letter soliciting his support and asking for membership recommendations.

Secure a commitment from each officer in your bodies to attain a petition for the next Festival.

Write a letter to each newly made Master Mason in each of the Blue Lodges your Bodies serve, including in the mailing a packet of materials about the York Rite. In this letter, you will want to encourage these men to feel free to contact your Membership team with any questions they may have. By all means, include a petition in the mailing.

Consider rewarding the member of your Bodies who gain the most new members during a calendar year.

Spread the leadership around by using some inactive members on York Rite committees.

Enlist the cooperation of all your past presiding officers. Include them in your plans.

Meet together on a regular basis with your planning committee and advisory committee to increase cooperation and a common goal.

Assign those officers and members who have speaking skills to a “Speakers Bureau”. Make this list available to Blue Lodges for their Masonic Education programs.

Develop a membership packet for new members. Include booklets and pertinent information that a new member would want and need.

Start very early. Most people cram too much work into too little time and not only lose effectiveness, but leave a sour taste.

Track your efforts and keep them going.

Build your infra-structure as strong as humanly possible. Use as many twenty-first century methods as you can.

Experience has shown that it is wise to have team members go in pairs to work with prospects. Any solicitation must be done on a professional level, with dignity. Treat any prospect as you would want to be treated. Some prospects take more time than others to “pull the trigger”. Don’t push. Patience is a virtue and will be appreciated by those who wish to think things through.

Invitations should be given on a personal face-to-face basis. Please do not treat a prospect as if he were one of many. He must feel that he is important and needed.

Team members must be knowledgeable and able to answer any question candidates may pose. Have appropriate information with you, but don’t inundate a prospect with more than he can handle. Some are more curious than others. Prospects need to know that we practice what we preach.

It is not difficult to sell York Rite Masonry. We have a lot to offer. Remember, we get out of York Rite Masonry what we put into it. We do need good dues paying members, but we really need to men who are willing to share in the load. A prospect will thank you after he has been through the degrees and orders and has become a full-fledged member of your Bodies.

Dedicated, qualified leaders need to be elected and appointed to the chairs. The first regular convocation a new member attends will be the one he most remembers for a long time. We never get a second chance to make a first impression. Our officers should be leaders who see to it that the work gets done in an efficient, orderly, and pleasant manner.

The number one function of our Membership team and the officers of our Bodies is to do everything possible to increase membership and build the manpower and effectiveness of our Bodies. This duty must be attended to on a constant basis. As leaders, the team must devote its time to the cultivation of membership functions.

Assimilating New York Rite Masons Into the Bodies

Bringing every new member into the active fold begins immediately upon his election into the Bodies. Notification of his election should be given to him in the form of a congratulatory letter. He will need to be assured that he has made the right decision and that his Masonic Education will continue and would be incomplete without his taking this step. He should be given the dates of the Festival and what is expected of him as he arrives.

The Degrees and Orders should be performed in such a manner as they at moments he will treasure and never forget. They should be performed in a dignified, meaningful manner. The ritualistic work requires your best and most talented ritualists. It will certainly be more impressive if members of his Lodge who belong to the York Rite Bodies are there to encourage and congratulate him. Please don't insult his intelligence or give him the wrong impression of York rite Masonry by reading the parts or performing them in a poor manner. Every candidate deserves our best efforts.

Also, the performances of the degrees and the time in between should be so efficient that no lost motion can be found. Everything must be well timed. The stage manager should insure that everything flows and all are rowing in the same direction. Men who can no longer perform or who do not have the talent to perform need to be encouraged to work in other areas. There is no part that is "MY" part.

After the degrees and orders have been completed, each candidate must be greeted warmly and allowed to express his thoughts. Each man should be given a job – regardless of how small. We need to get every new companion and sir knight involved – right then and there. Each candidate should be assigned a mentor (preferably his first line signer) who should give him instructions about the customs, traditions, and history of the York Rite. The mentor will need to take his new York Rite Mason under his wing until the new man is thoroughly oriented and comfortable.

The membership committee will want to follow up on each candidate to insure continued interest and activity. The sooner the new York Rite Mason is contacted, the more likely he will be to become a part of a vibrant, exciting organization.

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It is important to remember that men vote with their feet. That is to say, that with so many organizations and activities pressing each of us for a part of our time, we select those things which interest us and gravitate toward them, often to the exclusion of another activity or Body. We vote with our feet. We travel the direction that most interests us. We must never forget that we are competing for the time of men. We must succeed if our gentle craft is to continue on for our successors. Contact and interest are essential if we want our new members to feel needed and important.

We live in the information age. Men are busy and they mostly live in the fast lane. They are pressed for time. They want to know that they are trading that valuable commodity of time for something worthwhile. The moment they feel an activity is not worthwhile, they will vote with their feet. They must gain a feeling of belonging to sense fulfillment.

We need to get past the trap of “titles” and just be ourselves. Very few men care about all the regalia we wear and the initials each of us could place behind our names. They only care that we care.

Give it the most careful thought and attention. In order to assimilate new men into our beloved York Rite, we must make that all important first impression. Display the leadership needed to get the job done and make it happen.

Retention is Critical

NPD Personal Contacts

Equally important to attaining new members to the York Rite is retaining those we already have. In the past several years, we have witnessed a mass exodus from our rolls, both in demits and NPD's. This trend is a strong indicator that we are failing to pay the price of doing the work and are content in "playing" the game. We talk the talk, but do we really walk the walk? A letter asking for a demit and/or unpaid dues are cries for help. They are signals that we need to wake up and take notice. Somewhere, in someone's life, a decision has been made that a man is not receiving value for his investment.

It is the responsibility of the Retention Chairman to personally contact each of these men and inquire as to the reason(s) for this action. It cannot be overemphasized that the Retention Chairman plays a key role in the health and welfare of each York Rite body. Each contact will bring a new challenge for him, but he must make the call. Sometimes a member may be moving, other times his health may prevent his activity, and sometimes, he may simply no longer feel the need of belonging. Each case must be handled with love and care and individually.

Each request for demit and/or NPD has assumed the same vows each of us has, and he must be treated with the same dignity and respect that will effectively and firmly remind him of his commitment and allegiance. Should he be ill or financially unable to keep up with his dues, ways and means can be taken to assist our member.

Care must be taken with NPD's that each man is still a current dues paying member of his Blue Lodge. If not, then your Body has no option but to release him.

Otherwise, any man in jeopardy of going out of the York Rite as an NPD, needs to be contacted about his situation. The Secretary/Recorder can do much to help the Membership team in this area. Use his talents, understanding and information wisely. Have a plan of implementation and follow it. Remind each man that he is needed and he will be leaving behind a great deal of fellowship, Masonic Education, and opportunities for service should he opt out. Be proactive and work hard to retain each member.

Acceptance and Rippling (C) pages of this workbook is due to your District Deputy Grand High Priest by April 1, 2016. Retain the book for your reference.

Obtaining Restorations and Affiliations

When a member is suspended, there is still a chance that he may be restored into the fold. Often, his situation is traceable to finances, as opposed to dissatisfaction on his part. In recent history, many York rite Bodies have lost members due to the new Shrine membership requirement, and some are now beginning to want to return to the York Rite. The Retention Chairman should frequently review lost members to determine whether they may now wish to return to active status again.

The same holds true for demited members. Do not ignore the fact that he may be ready, willing and able to re-affiliate. The Bodies must be aware of the reason for demit. Bodies should review the inactive rolls annually to determine if there are any who might be ready to petition for active membership.

We must not suffer from the belief that once lost, always lost. It is time to open our eyes to the fact, that in our economy, financial conditions may change at any moment. The Membership team must take the initiative to seek out those who can and will restore and affiliate.

No one knows how many members could have been returned to the folds over the years. That, however, is no reason to “bite the bullet” and start now to contact these men. How many would be receptive to a kind word or deed? We must show that we care enough to be gracious to these men. The rewards of reinstatement far outweigh the efforts it will take to get in contact with the wonderful men. We must show our concern for the lost.

Stimulating Interest and Attendance

Value is the one thing men are looking to receive. Are we offering our members value for the hard earned dollars they pay in dues? Do we offer Masonic Education at our Convocations?

Leadership is very important in all our activities, but never more than in offering stimulating meetings and activities for our members. Good leaders find ways of interesting men to work for the Bodies. There are countless ways of stimulating their interest. Each man must be made to feel that he is a vital part of the team, not spectators.

Opportunities for service include:

- Committee assignment
- Ritualistic work
- Festival work
- Stage Manager
- Costuming
- Meal preparation
- Speaker's bureau
- Publishing a monthly newsletter
- Organizing nights to honor Blue Lodges, etc.

A little thought will reveal many more ways to utilize the talents of the memberships. Men will respond to an opportunity to serve. They will attend the Stated Convocations and be an active part of them. Ways to stimulate attendance include the following:

- Honoring Companions on the month of their Birthday
- Awarding of Service pins and certificates
- Recognizing achievement for Masonic or civic service
- Having a past presider's night
- Receiving and honoring outstanding Masons
- Celebrating the anniversary date of your Chapter

By a little creative thinking, the leadership of your Chapter can significantly improve attendance and participation in your local Bodies. Be bold and try them.

Conclusion

It has been the goal of this booklet to assist each local York Rite Chapter in its efforts to improve its membership base. It must be realized that no work can be accomplished in this world without exertion. It is therefore imperative that each local Chapter give the ideas in this booklet a try.

The time has come to put aside any “good old boy” networks and begin to utilize the talents, enthusiasms, and energies of those men who have plans and ideas to offer. We cannot afford to lose this good ship York Rite to those who cannot or will not do the work. We have too many companions who are more interested in rank, pomp, circumstance, and title than they are in serving the craft. Men who seek power, prestige, are stubborn to change, read their parts, insist on having their way, never offer anything for the good of Chapter Masonry, and/or encumber the progress of this beloved Fraternity, must now be gently and lovingly set aside in favor of newer, more energetic men who are willing to boldly step out in faith and are willing to take the risk necessary to turn the ship. Else, we will soon see the end of York Rite Masonry in the United States. As stated in the introduction, a look at the numbers will prove this statement true.

We must now find the men who will take a personal interest in membership and growth. We must return value for the investment of our members. We must be willing to change.

Your Membership Committee is both grateful and indebted to General Grand High Priest, Most Excellent Benny Allen, for allowing this booklet to be accomplished and to the Grand Encampment for its wonderful ideas on Commandery campaigns, from which much was adopted.

“We have come up thus far to help, aid, and assist in the noble and glorious work of rebuilding our city and the House of the Lord, without the hope of fee or reward. Will you go up?”